



Saint Columban College  
College of Computing Studies  
Pagadian City



## Scavenger Hunt

### Scavenger Hunt

Easy Web Exploitation picoCTF 2021

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#### Description

There is some interesting information hidden around this site. Can you find it?

Additional details will be available after launching your challenge instance.

82,856 users solved

picoCTF{FLAG}

Submit Flag

This challenge launches an instance on demand.

Its current status is: [NOT\\_RUNNING](#)

Launch Instance

#### Hints ?

1

You should have enough hints to find the files, don't run a brute forcer.

68% Liked

**Author:** The Analyst: Hyposelenia

**Challenge:** Scavenger Hunt

**Category:** Web Exploitation

**Date:** 02/17/26



## I. Objective

The objective of this challenge is to locate and reconstruct a hidden flag by exploring different parts of a website. This involves examining the website's source code, stylesheets, scripts, and hidden server files that are not immediately visible to regular users.

## II. Background

Web applications are built using multiple layers such as **HTML**, **CSS**, and **JavaScript**, along with server configurations that control how the site behaves. Developers sometimes leave comments, hidden files, or configuration traces behind—either intentionally or accidentally.

This challenge teaches beginners how attackers and security analysts explore websites beyond what is visible on the screen, using curiosity and logical thinking rather than advanced hacking tools.

## III. Tool Used

- **Web Browser** – Used to access and navigate the website
- **Inspect Developer Tools** – Used to view HTML source code, CSS files, JavaScript files, and other hidden resources

## IV. Methodology

1. Launched the challenge instance.

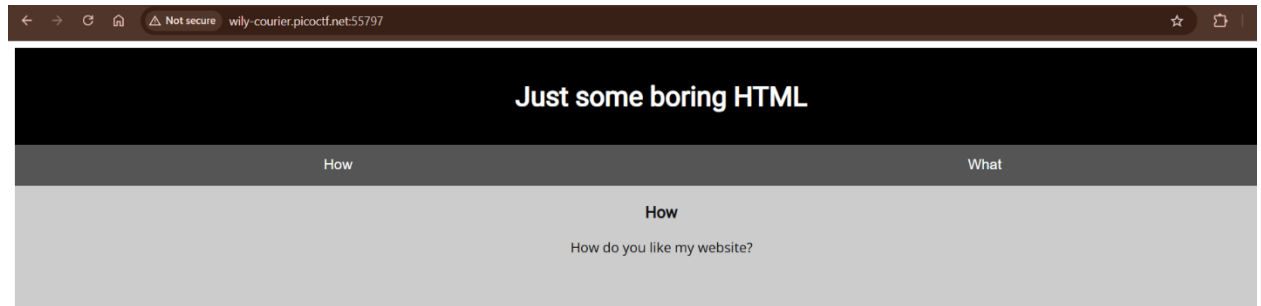
Its current status is: **NOT\_RUNNING**

**Launch Instance**

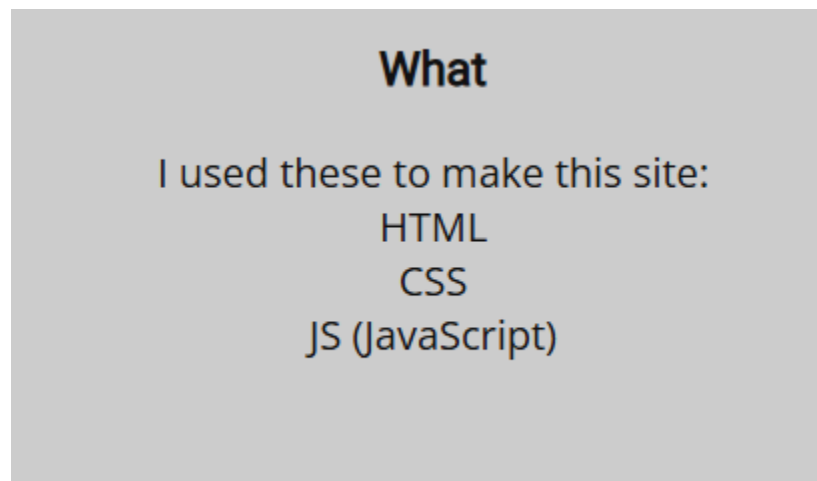
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2. Copied and pasted the provided link into the web browser.
3. Explored the website visually to understand its structure.

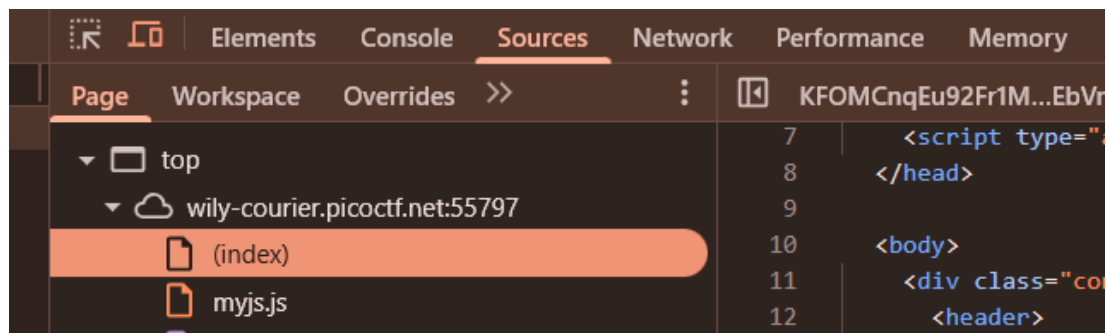
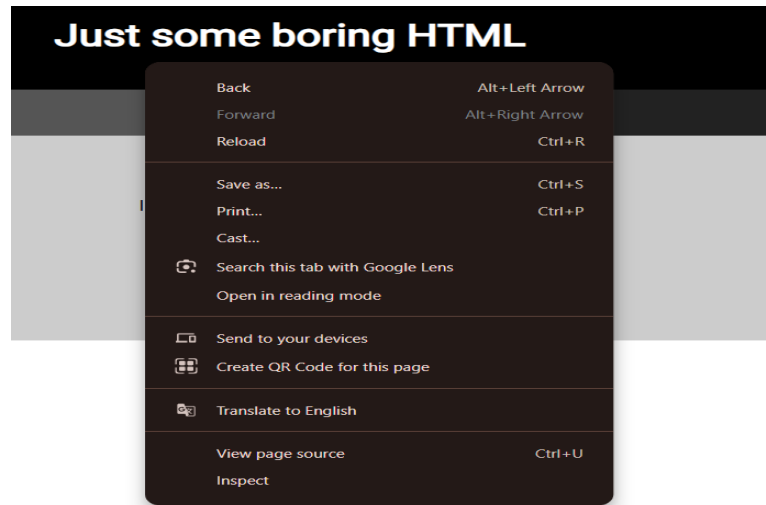


4. Noticed that the website mentioned it was built using **HTML**, **CSS**, and **JavaScript**, suggesting clues could be hidden in these files.





5. Opened **Inspect Developer Tools** and navigated to the **Sources** tab to easily browse these files. (Right Click or Fn + f12)



6. Found the **first part of the flag** hidden inside an HTML comment.





7. Checked the CSS file next and discovered the **second part of the flag** hidden as a comment at the bottom.



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45 ;
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47
48 -color: #ccc; }
49 -color: #ccc; }
50
51 look nice, and yes, it also has part of the flag. Here's part 2: h4ts_4_10 */
```

8. Moved to the JavaScript file, which did not contain a flag but hinted about preventing Google from indexing websites.



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10. Based on the hint, tried accessing hidden Apache-related files such as `/.htaccess`.

```
← → ↻ 🏠 ⚠ Not secure wily-courier.picoctf.net:55797/.htaccess

# Part 4: 3s_2_100k
# I love making websites on my Mac, I can Store a lot of information there.
```

11. Successfully retrieved the **fourth part of the flag**, which hinted about macOS.

```
# I love making websites on my Mac, I can Store a lot of information there.
```

12. Researched macOS hidden files and discovered `/.DS_Store`, then accessed it through the URL.

```
← → ↻ 🏠 ⚠ Not secure wily-courier.picoctf.net:55797/.DS_Store

Congrats! You've completed the scavenger hunt! Part 5: _9588550}
```

13. Retrieved the **final part of the flag** and combined all parts to reconstruct the complete flag.



## V. Result

**picoCTF{th4ts\_4\_l0t\_of\_pl4c3s\_2\_IO0k\_9588550}**

## VI. Explanation

To easily understand, Imagine a website like a **toy box** 🧸 :

### HTML (The Toy Shape)

HTML is like the **shape of the toy**. It decides where the head, arms, and legs go. Sometimes, notes are hidden inside the toy (called **comments**) that regular players don't see unless they open it.

### CSS (The Paint and Colors)

CSS is the **paint and decorations** on the toy 🎨 . Even though it's just for design, people sometimes leave notes inside the paint can — and that's where the second flag piece was hidden.

### JavaScript (The Toy's Brain)

JavaScript is the **brain of the toy** 🤖 . It makes the toy function or move should I say. Instead of a flag, it gave a clue about **robots**.

### robots.txt (The “Do Not Enter” Sign)

robots.txt is like a **sign on a door** 🚪 that tells search engine robots where they are allowed to go. The “Search Results” you see when searching in google.



Even though it's meant for robots, **humans can still read it**, which is why it's a common place for hidden clues.

## Apache Server & Hidden Files (A Big School)

The website runs on an **Apache HTTP Server**, which is like a **big school building** 🏫 that decides which rooms students can enter.

Apache uses **many hidden files** to control how the website works. These files are *supposed* to stay hidden, but if the server is not configured properly, **anyone can open the door and peek inside**.

### Important Clarification!

.htaccess is **not the only file** that can be accessed.

Think of Apache like a **filing cabinet** 🗄️ :

- .htaccess is just **one folder**
- There are **other folders and papers** inside too

Some examples include:

- **.htaccess** – rules for access and redirects
- **.htpasswd** – stores usernames and passwords
- **.conf files** – server configuration files
- Backup files like .bak, .old, or .txt
- Default or forgotten files created by developers

If Apache is **misconfigured**, these files may become publicly accessible just by typing their names into the browser.

That is why, in this challenge, trying /.htaccess worked — the server **forgot to lock the door** 🚪 .

## macOS & .DS\_Store (Mess Left Behind)





On **macOS**, computers create **.DS\_Store** files automatically.

Think of it like **crumbs left on the floor** 🍪. Developers sometimes upload them by accident, revealing hidden information.

### Now, Why These Exist on Websites?

- **Convenience for developers**
- **Automation**
- **Configuration control**
- **Accidental leftovers**

Attackers look for these mistakes. Defenders learn to prevent them.

### Why This Is Dangerous in Real Websites

These files exist to help developers **control and manage** websites, but:

- They were **not meant for visitors**
- They may contain **rules, paths, or secrets**
- Attackers can use them to **map the website** or find more hidden files

This is why security professionals always:

- Block access to hidden files
- Remove unused or backup files
- Properly configure Apache permissions

### Connection to the Challenge

The challenge intentionally allowed access to hidden Apache files to teach that:

- Hidden does **not** mean protected
- Web exploitation often starts with **simple curiosity**



- Misconfigured servers can leak information without hacking tools

## VII. Conclusion

This challenge demonstrates how small details across different layers of a website can reveal sensitive information. By carefully exploring HTML, CSS, JavaScript, and server configuration files, the full flag was successfully reconstructed.

The challenge emphasizes the importance of:

- Understanding how websites are built
- Checking non-visible files
- Thinking logically rather than relying on brute force

Overall, *Scavenger Hunt* is an excellent beginner-friendly introduction to web exploitation concepts.

— **The Analyst: Hyposelenia**